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HOW WE PLAY FOOTBALL

Helping your team take the next step.

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9V9 FORMATION GUIDE

2-2-3-1

A starting shape, four playing principles and a job for every position.



INTRODUCTION

WELCOME

An alternative way to organise nine players: two central defenders, two wing-backs, three midfielders and a striker. It asks for careful cover and realistic recovery runs.

WHO IT'S FOR

Volunteer grassroots football coaches and parents looking for a shared starting picture for 9v9.

The shape helps us explain jobs. Players should still have opportunities to try different roles.

HOW TO USE IT

- Learn the starting shape.
- Pick one of the four principles to talk about.
- Give each player a short, useful question.
- Use the online diagrams when you want to see movement.

IN THIS GUIDE

01 Starting shape

02 Four playing principles

03 A job for every player

04 Coaching reminders and notes

YOUR NOTES

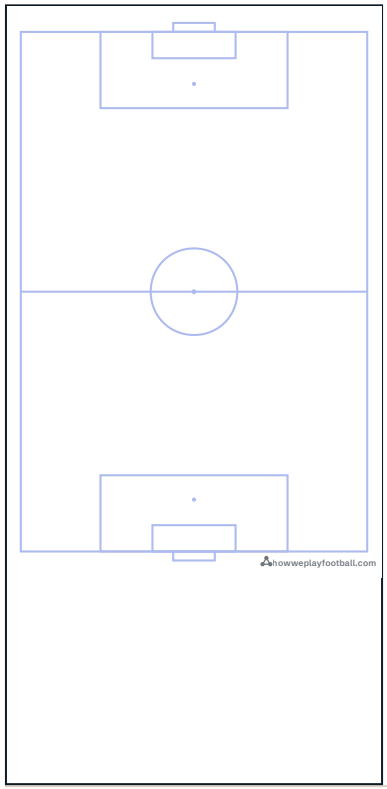
ON THE TOUCHLINE

01 Am I close enough to help?

02 If I go, who covers?

03 Who is stopping the pass through?

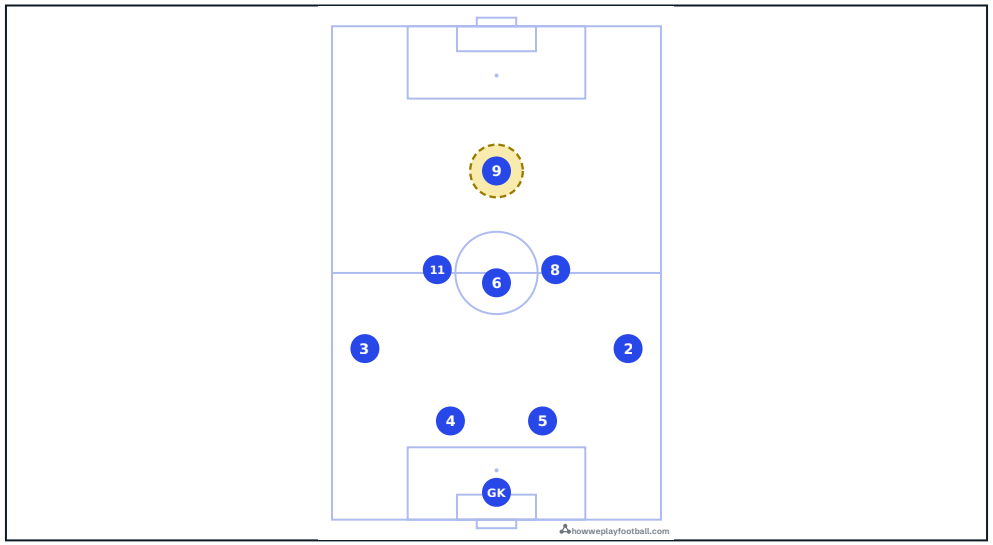
04 Press, protect or recover: which is my job?



CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

9 STRIKER

Give us a way forward



YOUR JOBS

- Make yourself available for a useful pass.
- Look for a teammate close enough to combine with instead of becoming isolated.
- Recognise when to put pressure on the ball and when teammates need recovery time.

ASK YOURSELF

"CAN I RECEIVE, TURN, OR HELP SOMEONE RUN?"

HOW TO READ THIS GUIDE

READING THE DIAGRAMS

We always attack up the page. These pictures capture a moment, not a fixed running lane.

OUR PLAYER
A blue player with a number.

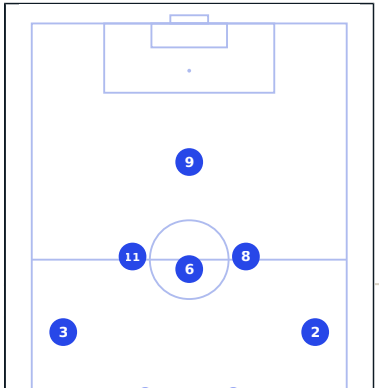
THEM
A player from the opposition.

BALL
Where the ball is in this moment.

MOVEMENT
A solid arrow shows a possible run.

PASS
A broken arrow can show a pass.

SPACE
A highlighted area draws your eye to a decision.



9V9 · 2-2-3-1

A STARTING SHAPE, NOT A FIXED PLAN FOR EVERY SECOND.

The numbers identify jobs in the drawings. They do not lock children into one position.

CHAPTER 01 · THE STARTING PICTURE

STARTING SHAPE

An alternative way to organise nine players: two central defenders, two wing-backs, three midfielders and a striker. It asks for careful cover and realistic recovery runs.



THIS SHAPE GIVES US

- possible wide support from two wing-backs
- three midfielders who may connect passes centrally
- one forward offering a higher passing option
- opportunities to discuss when players support and recover

REMEMBER

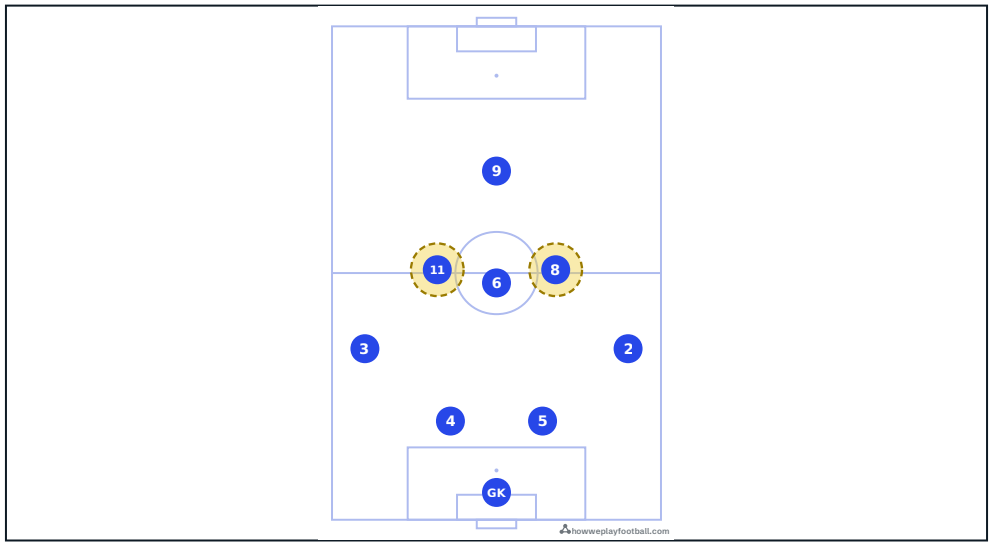
SAME STARTING SHAPE. DIFFERENT DECISIONS AS THE BALL MOVES.

9v9 · The 2-2-3-1 · Indicative player starting positions

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

11 · 8 INTERIOR MIDFIELDERS

Make angles, not crowds



YOUR JOBS

- Offer different supporting angles to keep possession moving.
- Notice where support is needed when the wing-backs advance.
- Help the team react when possession is lost.

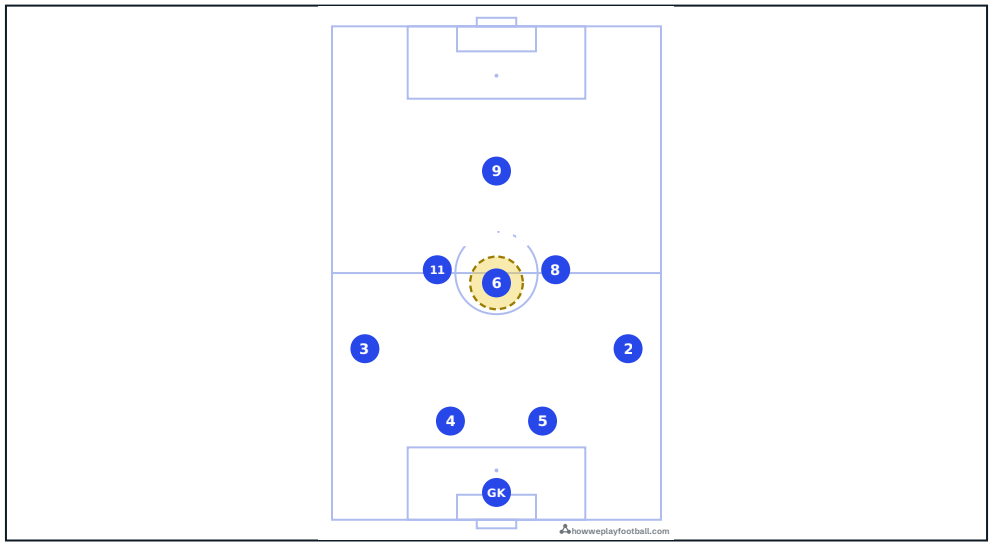
ASK YOURSELF

“AM I HELPING THE PLAYER ON THE BALL OR MAKING IT CROWDED?”

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

6 CENTRAL MIDFIELDER

Our connection and protection



YOUR JOBS

- Offer a central passing option without crowding teammates.
- Recognise when an advancing wing-back leaves space to defend.
- Help protect central passes when the team loses the ball.

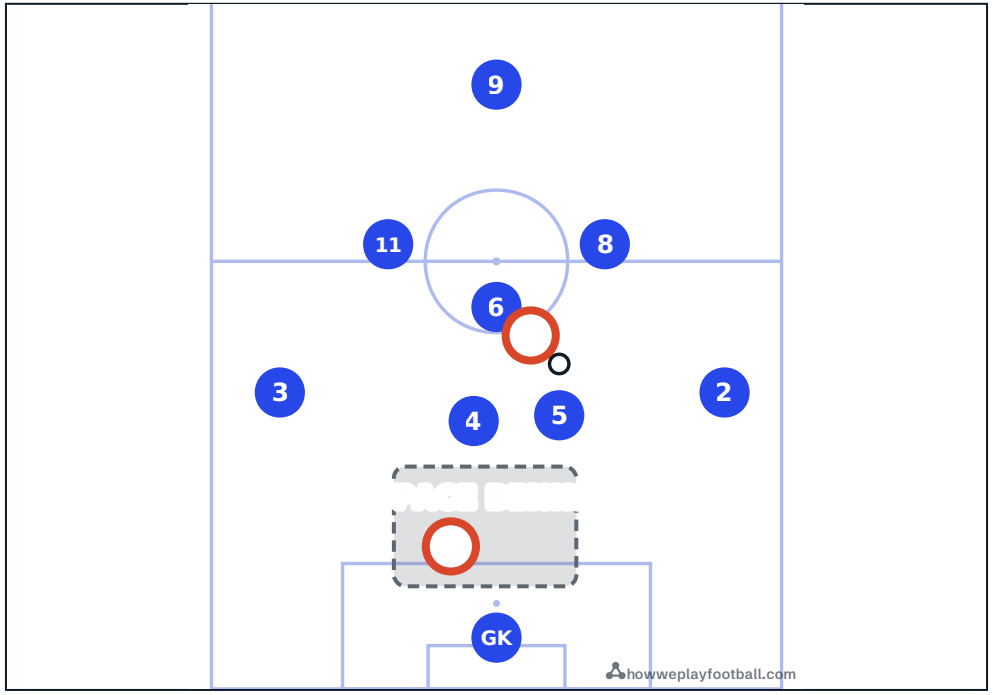
ASK YOURSELF

"WHO IS PROTECTING THE MIDDLE?"

PRINCIPLE 01 OF 04 · PICTURE ONE

TWO STAY CONNECTED

Our centre-backs defend together. The two defenders recognise pressure and cover as a partnership.



BOTH GO

Example: both central defenders step towards the same opponent, potentially exposing space behind.

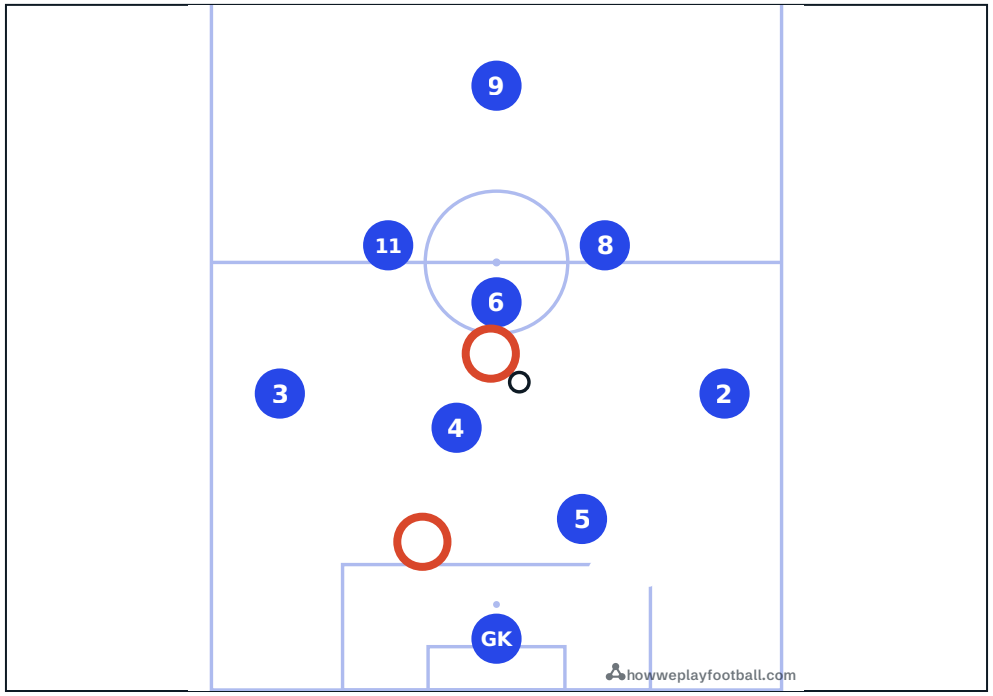
SAY IT

"AM I CLOSE ENOUGH TO HELP?"

One may have to challenge while the other is ready to cover.

PRINCIPLE 01 OF 04 · PICTURE TWO

TWO STAY CONNECTED



PRESSURE AND COVER

Example: one central defender meets the threat while the other provides depth and cover.

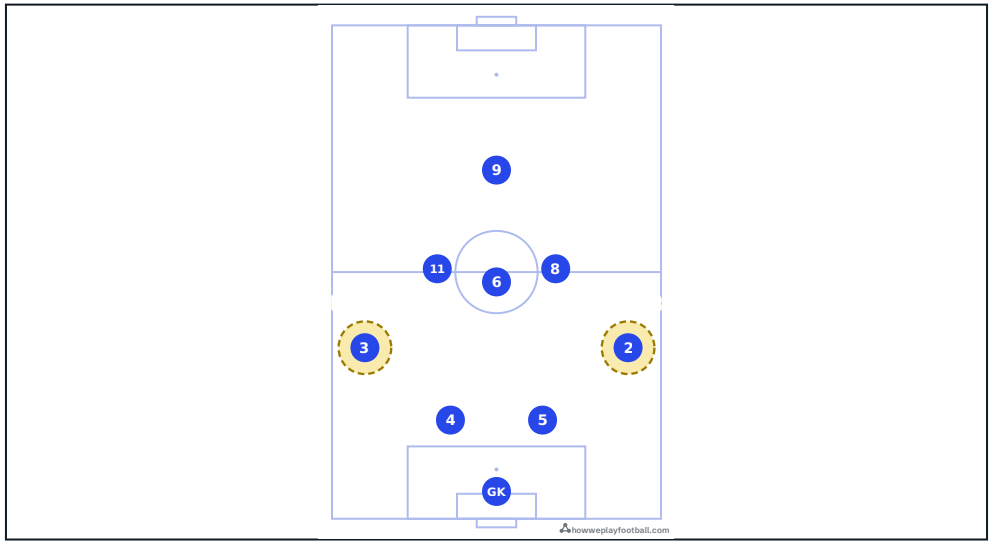
WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- Do 4 and 5 communicate about who meets the ball?
- Is either defender leaving too much space behind?
- Can one defender help if the other is beaten?

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

3 · 2 WING-BACKS

Two jobs, one decision



YOUR JOBS

- Offer a wide option when the team has appropriate cover.
- Recognise who can protect the area left behind when you advance.
- When possession changes, decide whether to delay the ball or recover.

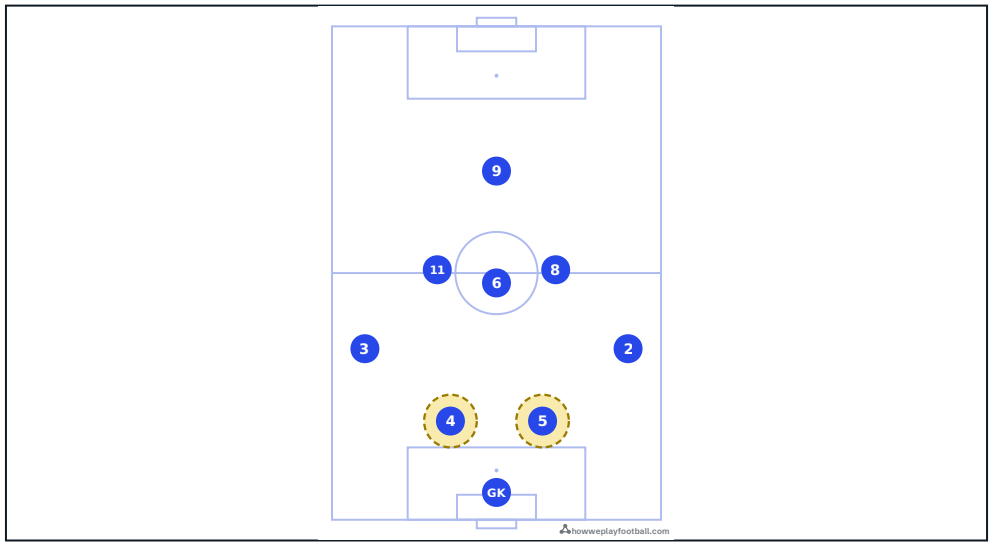
ASK YOURSELF

“IF I LEAVE THIS SPACE, WHO HAS IT?”

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

4 · 5 CENTRAL DEFENDERS

Protect each other



YOUR JOBS

- Stay aware of your partner when deciding whether to challenge.
- Recognise opponents threatening the space behind the wing-backs.
- Help protect the central route when possession changes.

ASK YOURSELF

“AM I THE PRESSURE OR THE COVER?”

PRINCIPLE 02 OF 04 · PICTURE ONE

WIDTH WITH COVER

Wing-backs go when someone can protect behind. Width can help our attack, but it changes the space we must defend.



STARTING WIDTH

Starting picture: wing-back 2 provides a wide option with central defenders behind.

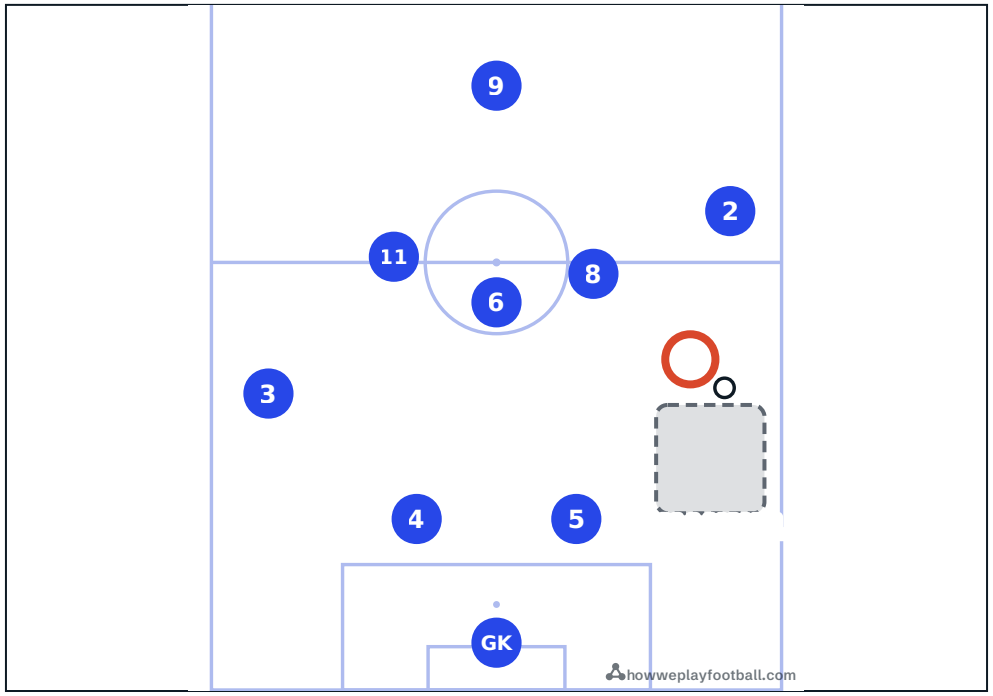
SAY IT

“IF I GO, WHO COVERS?”

The covering pattern depends on where the ball, defenders and midfielders are.

PRINCIPLE 02 OF 04 · PICTURE TWO

WIDTH WITH COVER



IF WE LOSE IT

Example: after a turnover, the space behind 2 becomes the next defensive decision.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- Is the advancing wing-back offering a useful wide option?
- Which teammate recognises the space left behind?
- Is the distance to recover realistic for this group?

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

GK GOALKEEPER

See danger early



YOUR JOBS

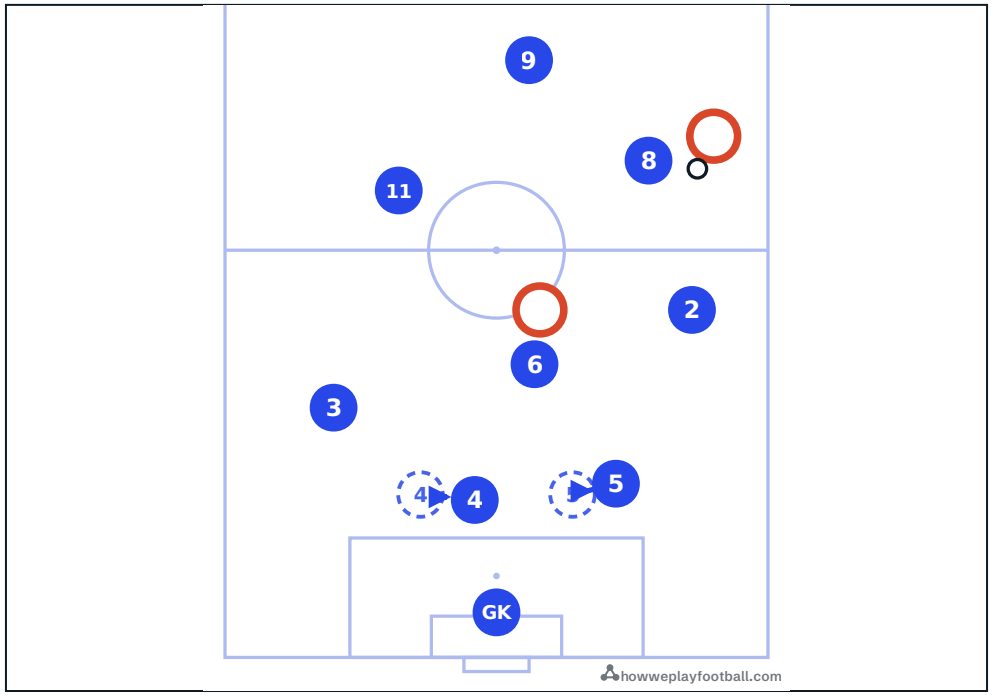
- Notice where the ball might go if the team loses possession.
- Help the two central defenders see and communicate danger.
- Find a sensible passing option rather than forcing play into pressure.

ASK YOURSELF

“WHAT COULD HAPPEN IF WE LOSE THIS PASS?”

PRINCIPLE 04 OF 04 · PICTURE TWO

LOSE IT? FIND HOME



3 · MOVE TOGETHER

4 and 5 move together. A back four is only an outcome of real recovery, not an instant switch.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- Can the nearest player delay the opponent with the ball?
- Who covers the central route during the transition?
- Are the wing-back recovery demands appropriate for our players?

PRINCIPLE 03 OF 04 · PICTURE ONE

SOMEONE PROTECTS THE MIDDLE

Don't leave the route to our goal open. A player must notice central danger when teammates support near the ball.



MIDDLE LEFT OPEN

Example: the central midfielder follows the ball towards the right while a central route may be exposed.

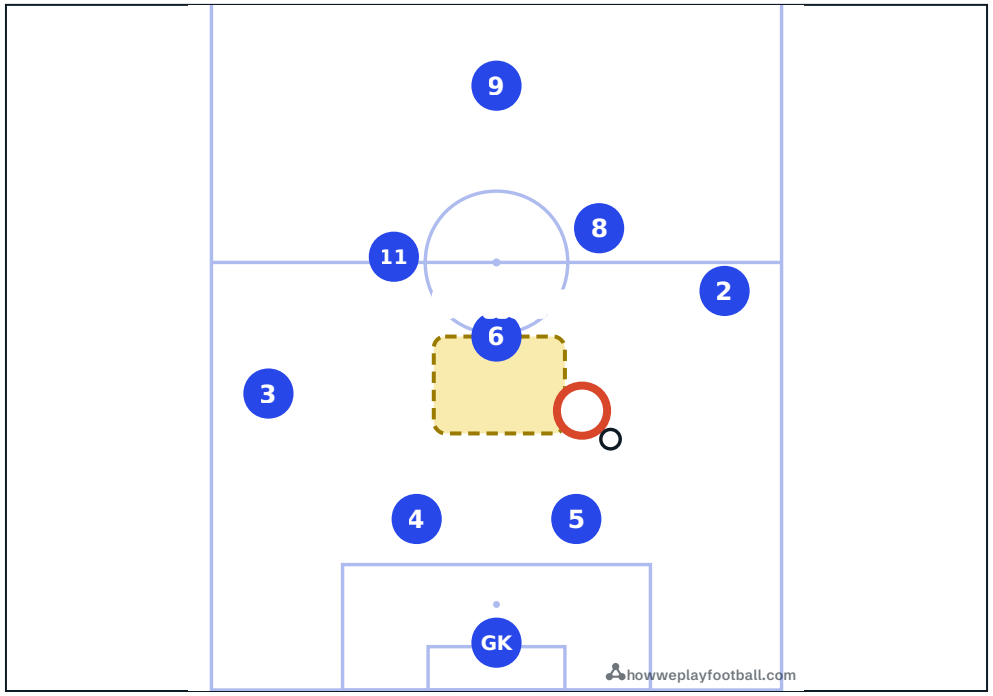
SAY IT

“WHO IS STOPPING THE PASS THROUGH?”

This is a shared team decision, not a permanent instruction for 6 to stay back.

PRINCIPLE 03 OF 04 · PICTURE TWO

SOMEONE PROTECTS THE MIDDLE



PROTECT THE ROUTE

Example: 6 notices the central route and maintains a protective position.

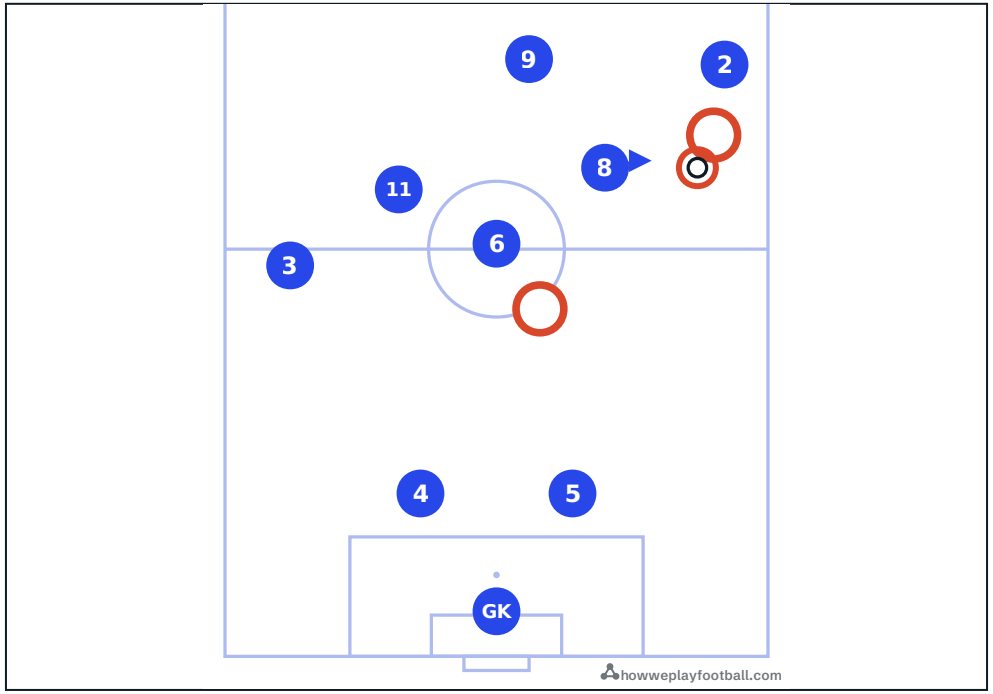
WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- Do we recognise when the central route is open?
- Can 6 connect play while noticing defensive cover?
- Are the other midfielders helping rather than crowding the same area?

PRINCIPLE 04 OF 04 · PICTURE ONE

LOSE IT? FIND HOME

Press if you can, recover if you can't. After losing the ball, choose the nearest useful defensive job.



1 · DELAY

We lose it near our right wing-back. The nearest midfielder, 8, delays.

SAY IT

“PRESS, PROTECT OR RECOVER: WHICH IS MY JOB?”

Find home doesn't mean blindly running to a fixed position.